Curiosity and a desire to learn "something" underpins many people's reasons for wanting to become a Freemason. Enquirers in particular often cite curiosity as a motive for joining in its own right (see "Motives for joining Freemasonry"). This quest for learning can continue throughout a Freemason's membership.

Our research tells us that members expect their Lodges to help them satisfy these personal learning needs. Indeed, we know that when Lodges don't do this, members can become frustrated, dissatisfied and leave.

As well as Lodges guiding members through what Freemasonry wants them to learn (see "Guided learning"), the most successful Lodges provide direct support for this personal learning, via the mentoring process.

GUIDANCE FOR LODGES

- Anyone new to Freemasonry will have lots of questions and seek a range of information.
- Do your best to satisfy rather than squash their quest for information while advising them to avoid seeking information about the ceremonies they are yet to go through.
- If the Lodge does not satisfy such curiosity and enquiry, they may turn to sources that are not credible or reliable, resulting in misunderstanding, confusion and the continuation of unhelpful myths.
- Refer them to Solomon, UGLE's online learning platform, and especially the section, "Seek & learn: About Freemasonry".
- Arrange for the Lodge Mentor to appoint a Personal Mentor who can help them.
- Ask Personal Mentors to monitor curiosity and questions to identify personal learning needs.
- Build common requests into the Lodge learning programme (see "Guided Learning").
- Encourage Personal Mentors to be assiduous in their activities and support them in their role.
- As a Lodge, monitor and record mentoring activities and their impact.
- Review the success of Mentoring and general Lodge health by monitoring attendance and levels of involvement, as well as members' sense of belonging and levels of satisfaction.

MENTORING ROLES

- Mentoring involves a "wise and experienced" member supporting the particular or individual needs of another member.
- Mentoring is not instruction in what we want new members to learn. That is covered by "Guided Learning". It is based on a one-to-one relationship of trust and understanding.
- The Lodge Mentor is a co-ordinator for the mentoring process, not the mentor to everyone else.
- Identify the members of the Lodge who are best qualified to be Lodge Mentor, by reference to the "Role profile for Lodge Mentors".
- If they are effective in their role, create consistency and continuity by keeping a Lodge Mentor in position for three to five years.
- The Lodge Mentor selects Personal Mentors suited to each new member, in consultation with their sponsors (see "Role profile for Personal Mentors"), and co-ordinates and supports their work.
- Lodge Mentors are supported by their Metropolitan / Provincial / District Grand Mentor, according to the local mentoring structure.

MENTORING AND PERSONAL LEARNING

- At all stages in our development in Freemasonry we can benefit from a Personal Mentor.
- However, the mentor themself may change as we develops and as our needs change.
- Mentoring is not haphazard, impromptu or casual.
- It is planned around identified and agreed needs under the headings of information, personal contact and one-to-one support.
- Mentoring is most active with new members but continues as "light touch" or "continued" mentoring for members as they meet new challenges (eg, progressive office, learning ritual, election as Master, being a Past Master, administrative roles, Metropolitan / Provincial / District rank).
- Only accept the role as a Personal Mentor if you can devote time to the members you are assigned.
- As a Personal Mentor, build good relationships to become a good friend and trusted counsellor.
- Recognise the individuality of members and, as their interests and personal learning needs evolve, encourage them to develop their own strengths and individual contributions to the Lodge and elsewhere.
- Protect members you support from undue pressure to accept any role or office or deliver any ritual before they are ready, or to join the progression to become Master when they don't wish.
- Value all strengths and contributions, and not just the traditional Lodge roles and offices, so that all members have the opportunity to play a part in the life of the Lodge irrespective of their rank or status.
- Continue to review a member's need for information as he develops, the personal contact he wants and the level of support that he needs to help him to achieve his potential within Freemasonry.
- Members who are happy with their Lodge, have their needs for personal learning satisfied and who are comfortable and satisfied as Freemasons, will – through their infectious enthusiasm – tend to attract visitors and new members.

OTHER ORDERS IN FREEMASONRY

- One particular form of personal learning is to join other Orders in Freemasonry.
- Chief among these is the Royal Arch, which is the completion of the journey begun with Initiation and therefore the natural continuation from the three degrees of the Craft.
- All Master Masons are encouraged to complete their journey in "pure Antient Masonry" by being Exalted into the Royal Arch.
- The timing of their joining should suit their own understanding of the Craft, personal circumstances and emerging interest in Freemasonry.
- Members of the Royal Arch tend to remain active Freemasons for longer than those who do not complete that journey.
- A good proportion of Royal Arch Companions go on to join other Orders and Degrees.
- This suggests that the Royal Arch, and membership of other Orders, can enhance interest and help retain lasting memberships of the Craft.
- Personal Mentors can help members decide when it is appropriate for them to join the Royal Arch and can protect them from overenthusiastic if well-intentioned "recruiters".